Natural Heritage

The outcrop at Matsieng is sandstone that belongs to the Waterberg series, which dates from Mid-Cambrian times (about 450 million years). The two big holes at the site are clearly natural and could be volcanic vents, which engulfed less bonded material. The holes are home to a variety of aquatic insects and vertebrates.

The insects occupy two habitats of the water bodies. The surface is occupied by the whirligig beetles (Dineutus aereus) that scavenge on insects falling on to the water surface. Below the surface there are predaceous backswimmers and diving beetles. There is also a wide diversity of insect larvae that live in this part of the pool. Two species of diving beetles have been identified, Cybister tripanctatus and Eretus sricticus, which are both fierce predators and probably feed on larvae and other mature insects in the water.

One species of frog Ptychadena has been recorded so far, but there are probably more species of frogs either resident or visiting during different seasons of the year.



Location

Matsieng engravings are in the southern eastern hardveld of Botswana, in the Kgatleng District (24 20.52S, 26 05.48E) near Rasesa village. Access is through the Gaborone-Francistown road through a turn off 5km from Rasesa village. There is a signboard indicating the direction of the site, which is about a kilometre from the tarred road and is accessible through a gravel road.

Some Rules

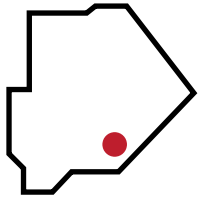
Matsieng is a National Monument administered by the Botswana National Museum and protected by the revised Monuments and Relics Act (2001). Adherence to some basic guidelines will make your visit worthwhile and ensure the continued protection of a part of Botswana's unique heritage:

- Use the designated parking lot, report to the Custodians' office and complete the visitors' book.
- Please do not interfere with the engravings or any other feature.
- Do not remove any artefacts.
- Cooperate with Custodians
- Take all your litter away with you.

PLEASE NOTE:
Researchers and commercial photographers, contact the Botswana National Museum for permission.



MATSIENG
rock engravings



Designation:
Natural & Cultural
Area: approx. 3km²
Adoption priorities:
visitor interpretation centre, field assistants, signage, trails

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
Private Bag 00114 Gaborone, Botswana
Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

BOTSWANA national museum

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

MT201511

Cultural Heritage Site

MATSIENG ROCK ENGRAVINGS

LENAO LA GA MATSIENG

According to the Matsieng Legend, Matsieng, the first man, is believed to be the ancestor of the Tswana people. The Tswana people believe that life began when he emerged from a hole in the ground followed by his people and animals. This happened a long time ago when rocks were still soft. Therefore, because of the texture of the rocks, their feet sank and left footprints when the rocks hardened.

Matsieng is one of the several sites in the country that could be referred to as “Creation Sites” because of it’s association with the myth of the origin of life. There is no explanation why Matsieng emerged from various places, but probalbly because of populating the Tswana territory.









Cultural Heritage

Matsieng is a site on a flat outcrop of sandstone, which extends over an area of about 100 by 80 metres. There are two large holes at the site, which retain water for several months of the year depending on the rainfall intensity, especially the one that is three metres deep. The three metres deep hole is usually referred to as the main hole because it is retains water longer, and has most of the engravings around it. Local people still collect water here for domestic use, religious rituals and to water their small stock.

Rock Engravings or Petroglyphs are a form of rock art. They are mostly found in the interior plateau of Southern Africa. Engravings generally offer a variety of animal tracks as opposed to rock paintings, which commonly have human figures. Matsieng engravings display mostly animal tracks (felines) and human footprints. Despite the legend, archaeologists believe that these are man-made tracks of animals and humans have been pecked or engraved on to the rock. The human footprints tend to be U-shaped with well-defined toes represented by dots or dashes at the open end of the U. Most human footprints are between 120 and 290 millimetres, with one giant-sized exception of 340 millimetres.

It has been suggested that there is some evidence to link the engraving symbols at least originally with Bushmen religious practices and possibly using animals for magic. It seems that such sites in Botswana were incorporated into Tswana mythology. In the case of Matsieng, it continued to be an important rainmaking place. The majority of these engravings are now badly eroded due to exposure to direct sunlight and rain. Human and animal activity also contributed to the erosion.

In the area around the main hole, there are several grinding patches and a few canoe-shaped sharpening grooves.